Big Picture Geography Syllabus

2026–2027

INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Instructor	Email	Room Location & Hours
Kirsten Decker	Kirsten@rivertech.me	Upper Middle School Room — Tuesdays, 1:00–1:40 PM

GENERAL INFORMATION

Description

This course gives students the big picture of geography, starting from the widest possible view and zooming steadily in: the universe and our solar system, then planet Earth and its maps, then the United States, and finally Idaho and their own hometown of Post Falls. Along the way, students build core map and geography skills through videos, hands-on crafts, games, and review activities, ending the year with an illustrated booklet project about Idaho and Post Falls.

Expectations and Goals

Students are expected to come to class ready to participate in activities, games, and crafts, and to complete any in-class pages when asked. By the end of the year, students should be able to identify the major parts of our solar system, locate the continents and oceans on a world map, name the regions and key landforms of the United States, and describe Idaho's geography in their own illustrated Idaho booklet.

COURSE MATERIALS

Required Materials

- The Complete Book of Maps and Geography (provided)
- A notebook or folder for notes

Optional Materials

- Coloring or drawing supplies for the Idaho booklet project

COURSE SCHEDULE

Quarter 1 (Sept.–Oct.): The Universe and Our Solar System

Week	Topic	Pages / Resources
1 — Sept. 1	Orientation week!	N/A
2 — Sept. 8	Intro to big-picture geography: what is the universe? Scale of size. God's creation.	Powers of Tens video; Creation video
3 — Sept. 15	Galaxies — what is in space?	Make-a-galaxy activity
4 — Sept. 22	Stars, black holes, supernovas, comets, etc. — fun stuff in space!	PowerPoint
5 — Sept. 29	The solar system	PowerPoint
6 — Oct. 6	Let's make our solar system	Fun activity!
7 — Oct. 13	Solar System Test	Test
8 — Oct. 20	Planet Earth	—
9 — Oct. 27	Planet Earth	PowerPoint

Quarter 2 (Nov.–Jan.): The World We Live In

Week	Topic	Pages / Resources
1 — Nov. 3	The world!	Pg. 319–320
2 — Nov. 10	Hemispheres / Latitude and Longitude	Pg. 334, 335, 336, 343, 345, 347, 352–355, 362
3 — Nov. 17	7 Continents and 5 Oceans	Pg. 318–324
4 — Dec. 1	Map	Pg. 332–333
5 — Dec. 8	Different kinds of landforms and bodies of water	Landform vocabulary bingo/scavenger hunt
6 — Dec. 15	Break/fun before Christmas break	N/A
7 — Jan. 5	Review day — map of the world and landforms	Kahoot
8 — Jan. 12	Test day	Test

Quarter 3 (Jan.–Apr.): The United States

Week	Topic	Pages / Resources
1 — Jan. 19	Intro to the United States, the continent	Pg. 288–291
2 — Jan. 26	The US!	Guess-the-state-name game; map of the US; Pg. 112–113
3 — Feb. 2	The US!	Pg. 97, 93–95, 103–104, 285
4 — Feb. 9	United States landforms — review from earlier	Pg. 130–132, 135
5 — Feb. 23	Natural wonders!	Slideshow; Pg. 139
6 — Mar. 2	Products and resources	Pg. 140–141, 146, 149 (take-home pg. 142, bring back)
7 — Mar. 9	Climate zones / review grocery-page discussion / intro to regions	Pg. 151–152, 154

Week	Topic	Pages / Resources
8 — Mar. 16	Regions	Pg. 174–175, 192–194
9 — Mar. 23	Regions	Pg. 209–210, 219–220, 233–235

Quarter 4 (Apr.–May): All About Idaho and You!

Week	Topic	Pages / Resources
1 — Apr. 6	Regions / Idaho	Pg. 260–262, 176–177
2 — Apr. 13	Idaho — landforms, climate, ecosystems	TBD
3 — Apr. 20	Idaho — History	TBD
4 — Apr. 27	Idaho — History	TBD
5 — May 4	Idaho — Economy	TBD
6 — May 11	Zoom in — Post Falls!	TBD
7 — May 18	Projects!	Illustrated booklets
8 — May 25	Projects!	Illustrated booklets

EXAM SCHEDULE

Date	Subject
Oct. 13	Solar System Test
Jan. 12	World Geography Test (map of continents & oceans)
May 18 & 25	Idaho Illustrated Booklet Project & Presentations

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION AND RESOURCES

Supplemental video links referenced in individual lessons (Powers of Tens, Creation, and others) will be shared by the instructor as each week comes up.